

LOVEBIRD • AGAPORNIS SPP.

Keep your lovebird the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: cage setup, the single-versus-pair decision, a pellet-forward diet, hormone and egg-laying control, and the routines that keep a lovebird thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Cage sizing and the bar-spacing rule that is genuinely a safety issue
- ✓ One bird or two, and what each choice actually gets you
- ✓ Three food charts, a pellet conversion schedule, and the never-feed list
- ✓ Seven health pages, a symptom table, and fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets

39 pages

Intermediate

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read pages 4 through 12 in order before buying anything. Two decisions are far harder to undo than the rest: the cage you buy on page 5, and whether you bring home one bird or two on page 9. Settle those first, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 28 to buy once instead of twice.

If your lovebird is already home

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Targets on page 26 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags page 19 if anything seems off. If the cage contains a happy hut, a nest box, or a mirror, read page 6 today. Those three items drive more lovebird problems than anything else an owner adds voluntarily.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 26: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 33: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 27: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 34: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 30: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 35: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 31: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 36: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Lovebird advice online swings between two extremes: treating them as disposable starter birds, or copying care written for parrots ten times their size. Neither fits. This edition is cross-checked against veterinary sources, listed on page 38, not recycled forum advice, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian experienced with small parrots. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a professional call, not a page in this book. Birds hide illness until they are genuinely sick, so find a vet before you need one and write the number on page 27.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Agapornis</i> spp., nine species; the peach-faced (<i>A. roseicollis</i>), Fischer's and masked are the common pets
Adult size	5 to 6.5 in (13 to 16.5 cm); 40 to 60 g (1.5 to 2 oz)
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years typical, up to about 20 with excellent care
Native range	Africa and Madagascar; savanna, open woodland and forest edge
Diet type	Granivore in the wild, kept on a pellet-forward diet in captivity
Cage minimum, single bird	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm); see page 5 for why sources disagree
Cage minimum, bonded pair	24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm)
Bar spacing	3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm), 1/2 in (13 mm) ideal. A safety figure, not a preference
Sexual maturity	8 to 12 months
Handling difficulty	Intermediate. Beaky and territorial for their size, and the pairing choice on page 9 decides how tame the bird gets
Conservation status	Most species Least Concern; Fischer's lovebird Near Threatened (IUCN)

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$190 to \$360 for equipment, plus \$25 to \$50 for the first vet exam. The bird itself is \$50 to \$150 for a common peach-faced or Fischer's, \$200 to \$400 or more for a rare color mutation, and \$20 to \$100 to adopt. Full breakdown on page 28.

Monthly ongoing

\$25 to \$50 for one bird, or \$45 to \$90 for a pair: pellets, fresh produce, replacement toys and vet care averaged over the year.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

A routine avian checkup runs \$25 to \$50. An emergency does not: egg binding, a broken blood feather, or a night fright injury can run into the hundreds or thousands. Egg binding is the single likeliest emergency in this species and it is a same-day problem, so an emergency fund matters more here than the price of any item on the shopping list.

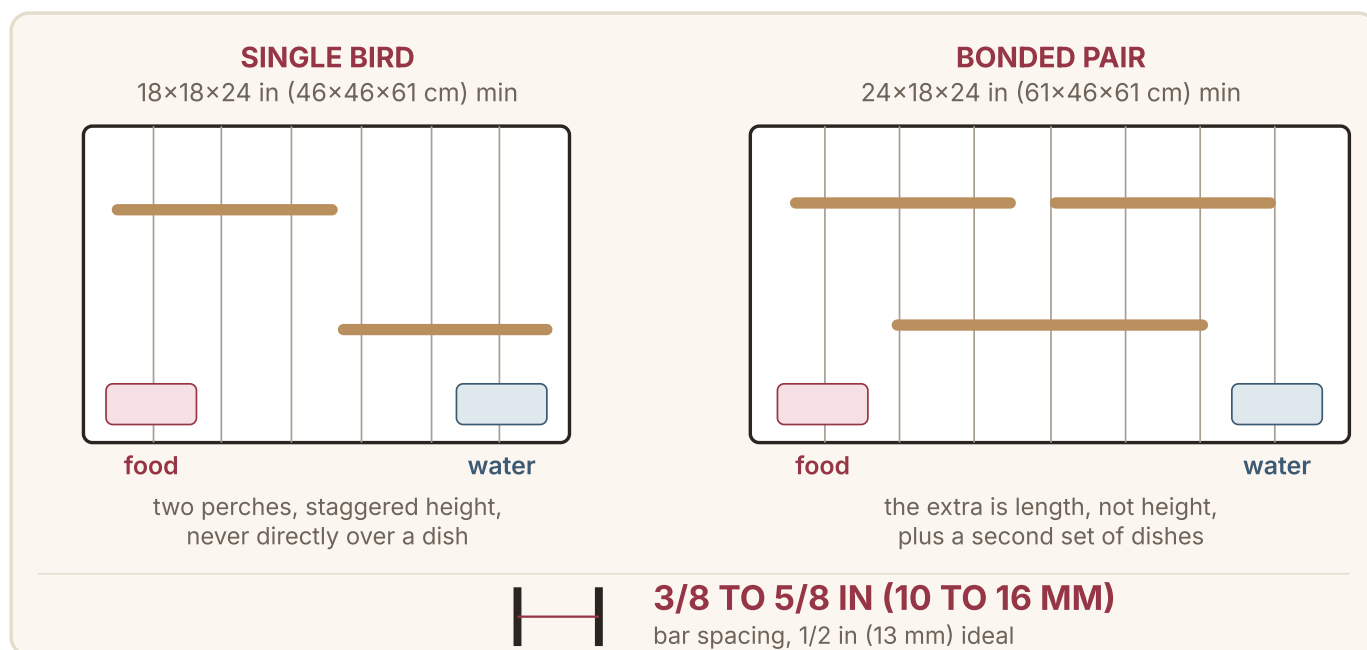
Fun facts worth knowing

- *Agapornis* is Greek for "love bird," after the bonded pairs that preen each other and sit pressed together for hours. The name is about pair bonding, not about being gentle with people.
- A hen lays eggs with no male anywhere in the house. It is not a sign of anything going right, and page 17 is about keeping it from becoming a habit.
- Lovebirds shell their own seed, so unlike some cage birds they need no grit at all. Offering it risks a crop or gizzard obstruction for no benefit.

Cage size, bar spacing & placement

18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) is the working minimum for a single lovebird, and 24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) for a bonded pair. Length matters more than height here: lovebirds fly side to side rather than climbing, so a wide flight-style cage beats a tall narrow one of the same volume. Note that VCA's lovebird profile sets a considerably larger floor, 3 ft long by 2 ft wide by 2 ft tall (90×60×60 cm). Treat the smaller figure as the least you can responsibly buy and the larger one as the target, and read every number on this page as a floor rather than a goal.

Bar spacing runs 3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm), with 1/2 in (13 mm) the ideal middle. This one is a safety figure: wider gaps let a lovebird push its head through and trap it, which can be fatal. Buy powder-coated or stainless steel only. Galvanized wire, homemade cages and cages with wooden components all carry a real zinc or lead exposure risk, and this is a species that chews everything it can reach. Skip round cages, which give a bird no corner to settle into.



NEVER

Buy a cage in the \$30 to \$50 bracket. Cheap cages rust, and a rusting or galvanized cage is a genuine zinc poisoning risk in a bird that chews its bars daily. Signs of heavy metal poisoning include appetite loss, regurgitation, weakness and excessive thirst and urination, and it is diagnosed on blood levels, not by looking at the bird.

Placement

- Against a wall at roughly eye level, so the bird can see the room without feeling exposed from behind.
- Out of direct sun, out of drafts, and out of the kitchen. The kitchen rule is not about mess, it is about cooking fumes; see page 8.
- In a room the family actually uses. A lovebird kept in a spare bedroom loses most of the social contact this species needs.

Perches, dishes & what to leave out

Perches

Natural wood branches of varied diameter, roughly 1/2 to 3/4 in (13 to 19 mm), beat uniform dowels. A bird gripping the same diameter all day loads the same points on its feet every hour, which is how pressure sores start. Vary the material too: one rope or cement conditioning perch alongside the wood is plenty. Site perches so nothing sits directly above a food or water dish, and keep the highest perch far enough below the ceiling of the cage that the bird's tail is not permanently bent against it.

Dishes and liner

Three dishes, for pellets, fresh food and water, changed daily. Exterior-mounted dishes are worth the extra few dollars: with a cage-territorial lovebird you can feed without putting your hand inside the cage, which is the commonest way owners get bitten (page 14). A plain paper liner, changed regularly, is the simplest hygienic floor. Avoid loose bedding that holds moisture and grows mold. This species needs no grit at all.

Furnishings checklist

- ☐ Three or four perches, varied diameter and material
- ☐ Exterior-mount food, fresh-food and water dishes
- ☐ Shreddable items: untreated paper, cardboard tubes, palm leaf
- ☐ A foraging toy that hides part of the daily ration
- ☐ Soft wood chew items, replaced as they disappear
- ☐ A plain, breathable cage cover for nighttime

LEAVE THESE THREE OUT, DELIBERATELY

A **nest box**, a **happy hut** or any enclosed tent-shaped hide, and a **mirror**. All three are documented triggers for hormonal, territorial behavior and chronic egg laying in this species, in a hen with no mate present. This is not a style preference, it is the single most avoidable cause of the reproductive problems on page 17. If you want the bird covered at night, use a plain breathable cover over the outside of the cage.

Toy safety

Lovebirds are unusually determined chewers for their size, which rules out several things that are fine for a calmer bird. Avoid small detachable parts, loose threads or rope fibers that can wrap a toe, open metal clips a beak can pry apart, and anything galvanized. Lead turns up in curtain weights, blind pulls, costume jewelry and cheap mirror backings; zinc in galvanized chain, bells, keys and mesh. Both are common enough in bird toys that buying from a bird-specific maker rather than a general pet aisle is worth doing.

Light, sleep & household climate

TARGET	°F	°C
Room temperature	65 to 80°F	18 to 27°C
Tolerable short-term range	60 to 85°F	16 to 29°C
Humidity	Normal household humidity. No misting system or humidifier needed	

No basking lamp, no heat mat, no thermostat. A lovebird is comfortable wherever a lightly dressed person is comfortable. What it cannot tolerate is a draft or a sudden swing, so keep the cage off the floor, away from exterior doors, and out of the path of an air conditioning vent.

Sleep is a husbandry requirement, not a preference

A lovebird needs 10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness a night, every night. Sleep deprivation in parrots is not a minor comfort issue: it is one of the recognized behavioral triggers for feather plucking (page 22), and a household that keeps the living room lit until midnight is effectively running the bird on a long summer photoperiod year-round, which is exactly the signal that starts a hen laying. Moving the cage to a quiet, dark room at a fixed bedtime is the reliable fix. A cover on the everyday cage helps some birds, but UC Davis's avian behavior guidance is that covering may not give a bird optimal rest on its own, because a cover stops the light and not the television or the people walking through. Consistency matters more than the exact hour.

THE PHOTOPERIOD LEVER

Daylight length is the strongest single control you have over hormonal behavior. Routine care is 10 to 12 hours of darkness, and Merck names an extended photoperiod of **more than 12 hours of light** as a documented risk factor for excessive laying, which is the line a lit living room crosses most evenings. For a hen who has already started laying repeatedly, VCA's guidance is to cut her exposure to daylight or room light to **8 hours a day** until the cycle breaks, and LafeberVet gives the same intervention as a slightly wider 8 to 10 hours. See page 17 for the full protocol.

Light quality and vitamin D3

Window glass filters out the UVB wavelengths a bird uses to make vitamin D3, which is what lets it absorb calcium. A bird sitting in a sunny window is getting warmth and daylight but not that. An avian-specific full-spectrum lamp above the cage, run on the same timer as the room lights, covers the gap for an indoor bird, and safe supervised outdoor time in a secure cage does the same thing better. This matters most for laying hens, where calcium demand spikes.

Signs your setup needs adjusting

YOU NOTICE	LIKELY MEANS
Sitting fluffed on the cage floor, or perched with feathers held out all day	Too cold, in a draft, or ill. Rule out illness first: a fluffed bird is far more often sick than chilly
Panting, holding wings away from the body, sitting near the water dish	Too hot. Move the cage out of the sun and off any heat source
Screaming at dawn, restlessness after dark, new plucking	Too little darkness, or a light or television left on past the bird's bedtime
A hen shredding paper and sitting in a corner of the cage floor	Nesting behavior. Go to page 17 before an egg arrives, not after

Household hazards & bird-proofing

A bird's respiratory system is efficient enough that fumes harmless to you are lethal to it. This page is the one most likely to save the bird's life.

PTFE FUMES KILL BIRDS WITH NO WARNING

Overheated nonstick cookware releases polytetrafluoroethylene gas at around **536°F (280°C)**, a temperature an empty preheating pan reaches in minutes. The gas is colorless and odorless, and the Merck Veterinary Manual is blunt that acute death is often the only sign. Merck also names irons and ironing board covers, some self-cleaning ovens, heating elements in some reverse-cycle heat pumps, and some heat lamps. Keep birds out of the kitchen entirely, and if a pan scorches, get the bird out of the house and open every window before anything else.

The rest of the airborne list

The same physiology applies to everything else you spray or burn. Aerosols, air fresheners and plug-ins, scented candles, incense, oven cleaner, bleach and ammonia fumes, hairspray, nail polish and remover, and fresh paint or varnish all warrant getting the bird into another room with the door shut and the windows open. Tobacco smoke is a documented cause of sneezing, discharge, eye inflammation and feather-destructive behavior in birds, and it lingers on hands: anyone who smokes should wash before handling. Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in any room with gas heat or a gas range: CO is odorless to you, and the bird has no margin.

Bird-proofing a room for out-of-cage time

- ☐ Windows and mirrors covered or blinds drawn, so a flying bird does not hit glass
- ☐ Ceiling fans off at the wall, not just the pull chain
- ☐ Toilet lids down, pots covered, sinks and any standing water emptied
- ☐ Doors shut, and a rule that nobody opens an exterior door while the bird is out
- ☐ Cables tucked away, and any lead curtain weights or blind pulls removed. Lead tastes sweet, so a bird that finds it keeps chewing
- ☐ Cats and dogs out of the room. Any cat contact is a same-day vet visit: *Pasteurella* can turn septic within hours

Toxic plants and foods in reach

Avocado is the one that matters most: every part of the plant carries persin, smaller birds are the more sensitive, and respiratory distress typically appears about 12 hours after ingestion with death possible inside one to two days. Never offer it, and never leave it within reach. Onion and garlic damage red blood cells. Chocolate, caffeine and alcohol are all off the list, as is anything containing xylitol. Common houseplants worth moving out of the flight room include philodendron, dieffenbachia, pothos, oleander, lily and sago palm. The full never-feed list is on page 12.

Night frights

Lovebirds thrash in the dark when startled by a headlight, a noise, or a shadow, and a panicking bird in a dark cage can break a blood feather or damage its cere or wings against the bars. A dim night light near the cage lets a startled bird orient instead of thrashing blindly, and it is worth adding for any bird that has done this once.

One bird or two

The decision that shapes everything else, and the one hardest to reverse.

Parrots are flock animals and need a social bond with something. A lovebird will form that bond with a person or with another lovebird, and whichever it forms first is largely the one you keep. This is not a preference to settle later. Make it before you buy.

CHOICE	WHAT YOU ACTUALLY GET	WHAT IT COSTS YOU
One hand-raised bird	Bonds to its person. Genuinely tame and interactive: steps up, rides on a shoulder, seeks contact and vocalizes back at you	Roughly 2 hours of direct daily interaction, every day, for 10 to 15 years. Not a bonding phase you graduate out of. Hand-rearing carries a documented behavioral cost too: Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006) found hand-reared parrots imprint on people and become socially dependent on them, with more aggression, feather picking and stereotyped behavior than parent-reared birds
A bonded pair	Bond to each other. Fascinating to watch, constantly busy, and largely uninterested in you. Closer to keeping a pair of finches than a tame parrot	A bigger cage, double the food and toys, and accepting that the birds are rarely reliably handleable
Two birds, not bonded	The risky middle. Two lovebirds of the wrong pairing can fight seriously, and lovebirds are territorial enough to injure each other	A slow supervised introduction, and a second cage kept ready in case it does not take

DECIDE BEFORE YOU BUY, BECAUSE PAIRING IS ONE-WAY

Once two lovebirds bond to each other, you cannot undo it to get an interactive pet back. And separating an established pair is not a clean break: bonded birds can visibly grieve a separation for 4 to 8 weeks. If your schedule genuinely cannot deliver daily hours, a pair is the kinder choice, as long as you go in wanting birds to watch rather than a bird to handle.

If you choose a single bird

Two hours a day is the working figure, and it does not have to be two hours sitting still. Out-of-cage time in a bird-proofed room, a short training session, food prep with the bird on a stand nearby, and talking to it across the room all count. What does not count is the bird being in the same house as you while you ignore it. A single lovebird that stops getting that contact is the classic candidate for screaming and feather plucking.

If you choose a pair

Buy a bonded pair from one source rather than assembling one yourself, and size the cage to the pair minimum from the start rather than adding a second bird to a single-bird cage. Both birds still need their own toys and their own foraging: a cage mate solves loneliness, not boredom. Have a second cage available before you introduce any two birds, and never mix lovebirds with other parrot species in the same cage.

A PAIR IS NOT A WAY TO AVOID HORMONES

A male and female housed together will breed if given anywhere nest-like to do it, and chronic laying is harder on a hen than any other routine part of her life. A same-sex pair or a pair with no nest site at all is the low-drama version. Everything on page 17 applies to a paired hen more, not less.

Diet: pellets, seeds & converting a seed eater

A formulated pellet should make up roughly **75 to 80%** of what a lovebird eats, with fresh vegetables and a little fruit making up the remaining **20 to 40%**. Seed is the part everyone gets backwards. It is a treat and an enrichment vehicle, never the base of the diet. An all-seed bowl is low in vitamin A and calcium and high in fat, and it is the single commonest cause of illness in pet birds: fatty liver, poor feather quality, chronic sinus and eye problems, and, in a hen, the calcium shortfall that turns routine laying into egg binding.

COMPONENT	SHARE OF THE DIET	HOW TO OFFER IT
Formulated pellets	75 to 80%	Available all day in a dish. Small-parrot or cockatiel-size pellets, not large-parrot ones a lovebird cannot break up
Fresh vegetables	20 to 40%, with fruit	Chopped fresh each morning, removed after a few hours. Weave leaves and herbs through the bars to make it a foraging job
Fruit	The smaller half of that 20 to 40%	Thumbnail-sized portions. High sugar and high water, so it goes further as a training reward than as a meal
Seed and millet	Treat only	Hidden in a foraging toy, or a small piece of millet spray 2 to 3 times a week. Never free-fed in a dish
Grit	None	Lovebirds shell their own seed. Grit is unnecessary and carries an obstruction risk

Converting a seed-addicted bird

Lovebirds are stubborn converters, and a bird that has never seen a pellet may not recognize it as food at all. Do not starve a bird onto pellets: a small bird has almost no fat reserve and can go downhill in a day. VCA gives two workable schedules. Weigh the bird before you start and **every day** through the change, before the first feed. Lafeber's limits are the ones to hold to: never let a small bird go more than **12 hours** without eating, and stop and call an avian vet at a **10% drop** from the starting weight, or if the droppings go minimal or black.

SCHEDULE	HOW IT RUNS
Gradual, 3-day steps	75% seed and 25% pellets for 3 days, then 50/50 for 3 days, then 25% seed and 75% pellets, until the bird is converted
Faster, 10-day taper	Start at 90% seed and 10% pellets on day one, then reduce the seed share by 10% a day until the bird is on pellets alone by day 10
If she stalls	VCA's own escape valve: hold at 20% seed and 80% pellets until the bird converts rather than forcing the last step. Expect days, weeks or months

Tricks that help: eat the pellets yourself in front of the bird, offer them warm and slightly damp, sprinkle a few over a favorite vegetable, and put them in the foraging toy while the seed sits in the plain dish. Confirm the bird is actually eating them, not just cracking and dropping them, by checking the tray.

SUPPLEMENTS ARE FOR SEED-FED BIRDS, NOT PELLET-FED ONES

A bird eating 75 to 80% pellets does not need added vitamins or minerals, and over-supplementing is its own problem. Give supplements only on an avian vet's instruction. A cuttlebone or mineral block is the usual exception and is worth leaving in the cage for a hen.

Never feed avocado, onion, garlic, chocolate, caffeine, alcohol, or anything containing xylitol. The full never-feed list is on page 12.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Safe vegetables, greens & herbs

Bright color is the shortcut: the orange, red and dark green vegetables are the ones carrying the vitamin A a seed diet leaves out.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Bell pepper, any color	STAPLE	High in vitamin A, and the seeds are safe. One of the easiest first fresh foods to get accepted
Broccoli, raw florets and leaves	STAPLE	Vitamin A and calcium. Offer small florets whole so it becomes a chewing job
Carrot, grated or matchsticks	STAPLE	Carrot tops are eaten too and are worth offering. Raw, not cooked and salted
Sweet potato, cooked and cooled	STAPLE	Cook it; raw sweet potato is hard for a small beak. Plain, with no butter or seasoning
Winter squash and pumpkin, cooked	STAPLE	Same vitamin A group as sweet potato. Seeds are safe in small amounts
Kale, collard, mustard and dandelion greens	STAPLE	Dark leafy greens. Weave a whole leaf through the cage bars rather than chopping it
Spinach and chard	OCCASIONAL	Good nutrition, but the oxalates bind calcium, so rotate rather than feeding daily to a laying hen
Snap peas, green beans, peas	STAPLE	Popular, and the pod gives something to work at. Fresh or thawed from frozen, not canned
Zucchini, cucumber, courgette	OCCASIONAL	Mostly water. Fine as variety, but they displace better food if they take over the bowl
Fresh herbs: basil, cilantro, parsley, dill	OCCASIONAL	Excellent foraging material and well accepted. Small quantities, offered as sprigs
Sprouted seed	OCCASIONAL	Better nutrition than dry seed, but sprouts spoil fast. Rinse well and remove within a few hours
Corn on the cob, small wheel	TREAT ONLY	Enthusiastically eaten and high in starch. A treat, not a vegetable serving
Iceberg lettuce and celery	SKIP	Not toxic, just nearly all water. They fill a small bird up without feeding it
Onion, garlic, shallot, leek	NEVER	Damage red blood cells. Raw, cooked or powdered, in any quantity
Avocado, including guacamole	NEVER	Persin, in every part of the plant. Respiratory distress about 12 hours after eating it, death possible in one to two days. Out of reach as well as out of the bowl

PRESENTATION IS HALF THE BATTLE

Wash everything well and buy organic where you can, because birds are markedly sensitive to pesticide residue. Chop small enough to pick up but large enough to hold, and try the same rejected food four or five times before deciding the bird dislikes it. Weaving greens through the bars, clipping vegetables to a skewer, or hiding pieces in a foraging toy all get eaten far more reliably than the same food in a bowl.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Fruit, extras & the never-feed list

Fruit is the smaller half of the fresh share. Sweet, watery, and easy to overfeed.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Apple, pear (seeds removed)	OCCASIONAL	Core and seeds out. A thumbnail-sized piece is a full serving for a 50 g bird
Mango, papaya, cantaloupe	OCCASIONAL	The vitamin A fruits, and the ones most worth offering of the group
Berries: blueberry, raspberry, strawberry	OCCASIONAL	Well accepted. Expect blue or purple droppings for a day, which is harmless
Banana, melon, peach, grape	TREAT ONLY	High sugar or high water. Small pieces, and best used as a training reward
Dried fruit	TREAT ONLY	Concentrated sugar, and often sulfite-preserved. Unsweetened and unsulfured only, rarely
Citrus	TREAT ONLY	Safe in small amounts, acidic enough that most birds take a taste and leave it
Avocado	NEVER	Fatal toxicity documented in birds
Fruit pits and apple seeds	NEVER	Cherry, peach, apricot and plum pits, and apple seeds. Remove before offering the flesh

Extras and "can I share this" questions

ITEM	VERDICT	NOTES
Cooked plain grains: quinoa, brown rice, oats, pasta	OCCASIONAL	Unsalted, unbuttered, cooled. A useful base for a chop mix
Cooked plain legumes: lentils, chickpeas	OCCASIONAL	Well cooked. Never raw dried beans
Millet spray	TREAT ONLY	Intensely liked and high in fat. A small piece 2 to 3 times a week, or as a training reward
Nuts and sunflower seed	TREAT ONLY	Very high fat. One kernel is a reward, not a portion
Cuttlebone or mineral block	KEEP IN CAGE	Calcium and beak conditioning, and worth having for a hen who lays
Dairy, meat, egg	RARE	Birds do not digest lactose. A crumb of cooked egg occasionally is the only one of these worth offering
Anything salted, fried, or sweetened	NEVER	Salt tolerance in a 50 g bird is tiny. Chips, crackers and processed food are out

THE NEVER-FEED LIST, IN ONE PLACE

Avocado. Onion, garlic, shallot and leek. Chocolate and cocoa. Caffeine, in coffee, tea and soda. Alcohol. Xylitol and other artificial sweeteners. Fruit pits and apple seeds. Raw dried beans. Salted, fried, or sugared human food. Anything moldy. Grit is not toxic but is unnecessary here and carries an obstruction risk, so it belongs on this list too.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- **A happy hut, nest box or mirror in the cage.** The most avoidable cause of hormonal aggression and chronic egg laying in this species, and it comes packaged as a kindness.
- **Seeds as the base of the diet.** Cheap, well liked, and the underlying cause of a long list of conditions in section 03.
- **Buying two birds while expecting a tame one.** A bonded pair bonds to each other. There is no version of this where you get both.
- **Buying one bird without the daily time.** Two hours a day for 10 to 15 years is the deal. A single bird that does not get it screams, plucks, or both.
- **The cage in the kitchen.** Convenient, sociable, and the most likely place in the house for the bird to die suddenly of PTFE fumes (page 8).
- **Bar spacing chosen by eye.** Anything wider than 5/8 in (16 mm) can trap a lovebird's head.
- **Lights on until midnight.** Under 10 hours of darkness is both a plucking trigger and a laying trigger.

Enrichment, by priority

Enrichment comes after correct cage size, diet, sleep and social contact, never instead of them. Wild parrots spend an estimated 60 to 80% of their waking hours foraging, and a bowl of food deletes almost all of that at a stroke. In this order:

1. Foraging

Hide part of the daily ration rather than serving all of it. A foraging box, pellets wrapped in a paper cup, or food buried under shredded paper. Parrots will often work for food while a free bowl sits nearby, which tells you the work is the point.

2. Shredding

Untreated paper, cardboard tubes, palm leaf mats and balsa. Lovebirds are enthusiastic shredders and soft wood disappears fast, so keep a cheap rotating supply rather than one expensive toy.

3. Chewing

Harder bird-safe wood for the beak to actually work at. This is also what keeps a beak in condition without a trim.

4. Out-of-cage time

One to two hours daily in a bird-proofed room, supervised. Flight is exercise a cage cannot provide at this size.

5. Training

Short positive-reinforcement sessions, a few minutes at a time. Step up, target training, recall. Cognitively demanding in a way toys are not, and it builds the handling relationship at the same time.

6. Rotation

Three to five toys in the cage at once, swapped weekly. More than that crowds out flight space. A toy that has been away for a few weeks reads as new again, which stretches a small collection a long way.

Handling, taming & the bite problem

The name oversells the temperament. Veterinary sources are direct that lovebirds can be very territorial and aggressive when frightened or threatened, especially hens and especially during hormonal periods, and a lovebird will readily chase a bird several times its size, or the family dog, out of what it considers its space. None of that makes it a bad pet. It makes it a bird that has to be handled on its own terms.

Reading the bird before you reach

Almost every bite is preceded by a warning that the person missed. Learn these four and you will get bitten a fraction as often: **eye pinning**, where the pupils rapidly shrink and widen; **feathers held tight to the body with a forward lean**; **a raised foot or an open beak held toward your hand**; and **lunging or a sharp click**. A relaxed bird is loosely fluffed, grinding its beak, or standing on one leg. That bird will step up. The other one will not, and pushing it teaches it that warnings do not work, which is how you get a bird that bites with no warning at all.

Taming, in order

- Sit beside the cage and talk, doing nothing else, until the bird stops moving away from you.
- Offer a piece of millet through the bars, then from an open palm inside the cage, then from your fingers.
- Teach step up onto a stick first, outside the cage, in a neutral room. Stick training is safer and faster than reaching in with a hand, and it gives you a way to move an angry bird without a fight.
- Move to a finger for step up once the stick is reliable, always in the neutral room before ever trying it in the cage.
- Keep sessions short, several times a day, and end while it is going well rather than pushing for one more repetition.

CAGE AGGRESSION HAS A MECHANICAL FIX

Most cage aggression is territorial, so the fastest wins are structural rather than behavioral: remove any nest-like object, fit exterior food dishes so you never reach in to feed, and take the bird to a neutral room before asking anything of it. Aggression very often eases the moment the bird is away from the cage it is defending.

If you are bitten

Do not shout, jerk your hand away, or flick the bird. A dramatic reaction is interesting, and an interesting result reinforces the behavior. Put the bird down calmly, end the session without ceremony, and work out what warning you walked past. Wash any broken skin properly: a bird bite is a puncture, and it is worth a doctor's opinion if it swells.

WHERE LOVEBIRDS SIT AGAINST OTHER SMALL PARROTS

Beakier and more territorial for their size than a budgie or a cockatiel, more determined chewers, and never to be housed with other species. A lovebird that is well socialized and handled from young is no harder than any other small parrot. One that is not can be a genuinely difficult bird, and hormonal seasons make any of them worse for a few weeks at a time.

Wing clipping & flight

A decision nearly every new owner is asked to make in the first week, usually by someone selling the trim.

Clipping means trimming some of the primary flight feathers so the bird cannot gain height, until it molts those feathers out and grows them back. It is not permanent and it is not surgery. It is also not the routine default it once was: professional and owner opinion has shifted considerably toward keeping companion birds flighted, on the grounds that flight is exercise, coordination and confidence, not just transport.

The case for clipping

- A bird that cannot gain height cannot fly out of a door or window that someone opens without thinking.
- It cannot reach a ceiling fan, a hot stove, or a window it does not know is there.
- Handling and step-up training are easier early on, because flying away is not an option.

The case against

- Flight is the bird's main exercise. A clipped bird builds less muscle and less coordination.
- An over-clipped bird falls rather than glides, and falls cause keel injuries and split ceres.
- Clipping does not fix a behavior problem. A bird that bites clipped will bite flighted.

IF IT IS DONE, IT IS DONE RIGHT OR NOT AT ALL

Only mature feathers are ever cut. Merck's method is **four to seven of the outermost primary feathers on both wings**, cut below the coverts that overlay them, leaving the secondaries closer to the body alone, because those are what let a bird slow down and land. A heavier bird needs fewer taken and a lighter, more agile one more, and clipping only one wing is not recommended. A **blood feather** is a growing feather with a live blood supply in the shaft, and cutting, breaking or pulling one causes real bleeding that a small bird cannot afford. A correct trim leaves the bird able to glide down to the floor under control, not drop. A trim that leaves it dropping is too short, and it has to grow out. Have an avian vet do the first one and watch how it is done. A pet shop trim done in two minutes is where most bad clips come from.

If you keep the bird flighted

The safety burden moves to the room instead of the bird, which is the trade. Train a recall cue with a food reward so you can call the bird back rather than chase it, and run this checklist before every session.

The full bird-proofing checklist is on page 8. Run it before every session.

Either way, do these two things

- **Microchip or leg band details written down**, and a clear photograph of your bird, kept where you can find it in the first ten minutes of a bird getting out. A clipped bird still gets carried by a gust of wind.
- **Check the wings at every weekly weigh-in.** Clipped feathers grow back unevenly, and a bird with three regrown primaries on one side is more likely to crash than one that is fully clipped or fully flighted.

A BROKEN BLOOD FEATHER IS A FIRST-AID SITUATION

It bleeds more than the size suggests. Apply **firm, steady pressure** with clean gauze, and put styptic powder or cornstarch on the exposed broken tip of the shaft, **never down into an open follicle**, which can damage the follicle permanently. If it has not stopped within two to three minutes, call an avian vet. Do not pull the feather: VCA's current guidance is that pulling one at home is not recommended, because it leaves the shaft open and can cost more blood than it saves, and even in a clinic it is a last resort.

Sexing, weight & body condition

Telling male from female

You mostly cannot, by eye. In the commonly kept species there are no reliable external differences between the sexes; hens typically weigh a little more than cocks, which is a tendency rather than a test. Blood or feather DNA testing is how it is actually determined, it is inexpensive, and an avian vet can run it at the first wellness exam. Behavioral hints exist and are worth noticing, but none of them are conclusive, and a bird laying an egg is the only free answer that is.

WHY IT IS WORTH KNOWING

Sex changes what you watch for. A hen needs the hormone and egg-laying management on page 17, the calcium note on page 10, and a lower threshold for calling a vet about straining or lethargy. If you keep two birds and one is a hen, knowing whether the other is a cock decides whether you are managing a bonded pair or a breeding pair.

Weight is this species' vital sign

A lovebird hides illness until it is genuinely sick, and weight is the measurement that moves first. Buy a digital kitchen scale that reads to 1 g, teach the bird to step onto a perch fixed to it, and weigh at the same time each day, before the first feed. Lafeber's Susan Orosz is specific: a scale reading grams rather than ounces, used daily, with the number written down, because it is the chart rather than any single reading that shows a trend. Log it on page 34.

MEASURE	HEALTHY ADULT RANGE
Body weight	40 to 60 g (1.5 to 2 oz), depending on species and frame. What matters is your bird's own stable number, not where it falls in the range
Length, beak to tail tip	5 to 6.5 in (13 to 16.5 cm)
Day-to-day variation	A gram or two either way is normal. Weight is taken before the first feed of the day for consistency
A vet call	A sustained drop of about 10% of body weight, which for a 50 g bird is only 5 g, or any steady downward trend across three weigh-ins

Body condition at a glance

Feel the keel, the ridge of bone running down the center of the chest, with a fingertip either side. In birds it is scored 1 to 5, and obesity is generally taken as roughly 20% over ideal weight or a score of 4 out of 5.

UNDERWEIGHT

The keel stands out as a sharp ridge with a hollow either side. Combined with a weight drop, this is a vet visit, not a feeding adjustment.

IDEAL

The keel is easy to feel but the muscle either side rises to meet it, giving a shallow V rather than a knife edge.

OVERWEIGHT

The keel is hard to find under the muscle and the chest feels rounded or flat. Usually a seed diet plus too little flying.

A rounded chest and a keel you cannot find is the start of fatty liver disease, which is covered with the rest of the nutritional conditions on page 23.

Hens, chronic egg laying & egg binding

Lovebirds are one of the species most over-represented for both. This page is prevention first, because treatment is worse than prevention every time.

Why a lone hen lays at all

A hen does not need a male, or even another bird, to lay. Laying is triggered by a combination of long day length, abundant food, a nest-like place to sit, and a bond to something she treats as a mate, which can be her owner. Budgerigars, cockatiels and lovebirds are the three species named most often for chronic laying, and in small birds there is likely a genetic component too. Chronic laying drains calcium faster than a hen can replace it, which is what turns a normal clutch into a soft-shelled egg, a fracture, or a bird that cannot pass the next one.

Turning the triggers off

TRIGGER	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
Long day length	Cut light exposure to 8 hours a day until laying stops, then return to a steady 10 to 12 hours of darkness
Nest sites	Remove the happy hut, tent, nest box, and any dark enclosed corner she can sit in. Take out shreddable paper temporarily
A perceived mate	Stop stroking her back and under her tail, which is a mating signal, and cut the total handling time back. Remove mirrors. Separate a male into another room
Abundant rich food	Move fully to pellets and cut high-fat treats. Keep the cuttlebone available for calcium
A comfortable, unchanging territory	Rearrange the cage furniture, or move the cage to a different spot. Reducing how secure the site feels genuinely reduces laying

DO NOT JUST TAKE THE EGGS AWAY

Pulling a clutch usually prompts her to replace it, which is the opposite of what you want. The standard advice is to let her sit the clutch through a full incubation cycle, then remove the eggs gradually, one every day or two. For a lovebird that cycle is **18 to 24 days**, LafeberVet's species figure rather than the 21 to 28 days quoted as a general parrot range. Use the species number: it is the bird's own biology that decides when she gives up on a clutch. Where a hen is laying repeatedly, an avian vet has real options: hormone injections that pause laying for 3 to 4 weeks, a deslorelin implant lasting 3 to 6 months or longer, or, as a last resort, surgery.

The calcium cost of laying

Repeated clutches on a calcium-poor diet drain a hen faster than she can replace them. Signs run from weakness and tremors to seizures and to fractures that happen with no obvious injury. Prevention is a pellet-based diet, a cuttlebone left in the cage, the vitamin D3 note on page 7, and controlling the laying itself with the trigger list above. Treatment is injected calcium, at a vet's hands.

AFTER AN EPISODE

A hen who has been egg bound once is likely to lay again, so the visit is only half the job. Go back to the trigger list above and work it properly: light down to 8 hours, every nest-like object out, no back stroking, and a full move to pellets. Ask the vet about a hormone injection or a deslorelin implant to buy time while the husbandry changes take effect, and about spaying as a last resort for a hen who keeps cycling despite all of it.

Egg binding

The likeliest emergency this species will ever present you with, and the one where hours genuinely decide the outcome.

An egg that cannot pass presses on the kidneys, on the nerves running to the legs, and on the airway, because a bird has no diaphragm to protect its lungs from abdominal pressure. It kills quickly and it does not resolve on its own. Lovebirds are named alongside cockatiels and budgerigars as the species this happens to most.

Signs, in roughly the order they appear

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS
Straining, tail pumping, a wide-legged stance	She is trying to pass it and cannot. This is already the emergency
Sitting on the cage floor, fluffed, eyes closing	A bird that cannot perch is seriously compromised
A swollen, firm-looking abdomen	The egg, or fluid around it. Do not press on it
An egg visible at the vent, or tissue prolapsing from it	Late, and it does not mean the egg is about to pass. Same-day vet, and do not pull at it
No egg passed in 48 hours by a hen you know is laying	VCA's marker, and on its own it is enough to make the call before the rest of this list appears
Tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing	The egg is limiting how far the air sacs can expand
Weakness in one or both legs, or a leg that drags	Pressure on the nerves to the legs. It usually resolves once the egg is out
Fewer droppings, or none since yesterday	The egg is obstructing. Check the cage liner before you clean it

What causes it

Calcium deficiency is the biggest one, and page 17 covers what repeated laying costs a hen. It is why an all-seed diet sits underneath most cases: a hen short of calcium produces soft or misshapen eggs and cannot contract properly to move them. Vitamin A deficiency, obesity, a very first clutch, laying too many clutches in a row, oviduct disease, and general poor husbandry all raise the risk.

What the vet does

Fluids and injected calcium first, then warmth and humidity, pain relief and anti-inflammatories. Oxytocin, given by injection, may be used to induce contractions and can be repeated once. If she still cannot pass the egg, it is removed manually under anesthetic, or surgically. The outlook is fair to good when a hen is treated promptly and poor when the delay runs into days.

CALL THE VET NOW, NOT IN THE MORNING

Do not attempt to lubricate, massage, or extract an egg yourself. A ruptured egg inside the oviduct is a far worse problem than the one you started with. Put her in a small carrier on a folded towel, keep her dark and quiet, and go. Bring today's cage liner. Warm her to around **80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C)** on the way: that sits inside the 80 to 90°F (27 to 32°C) range LafeberVet gives for a bird under supplemental heat, where VCA puts a recovering bird's ideal at 75 to 80°F (22 to 25°C). Watch for overheating, which shows as flat, sleek feathers, wings held out from the body, and open-mouth breathing.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT AN AVIAN VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE
Sitting fluffed with eyes closing during the day · tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, wheezing or a tail-bob at rest · a hen straining, sitting on the cage floor, or standing wide-legged · discharge from the nostrils or eyes · feather or beak deformity · plucking down to bare skin · a drop in appetite or droppings · a fall, a bleeding feather, or any contact with a cat or dog.

Why "wait and see" does not apply to birds

A prey species that shows weakness in the wild is the one that gets taken, so a lovebird conceals illness until concealment stops working. By the time a bird looks unwell to a person across the room, it has usually been sick for a while and has burned through what little reserve a 50 g body holds. That is why the threshold in this package is deliberately low: any clear deviation from that bird's normal is a call, not an observation to make again tomorrow. Tail bobbing in particular is a late sign, not an early one. It means the tail muscles have been recruited to help with breathing.

What the vet will ask for is listed on the emergency card on page 27. Fill that card in now, while the bird is well, rather than trying to assemble it during a phone call.

Why diet comes up first at every appointment

Improper diet is one of the most common underlying causes of illness in pet birds, and an all-seed or half-seed diet is deficient in vitamin A whether or not the bird looks well on it. A vet asking about the food bowl before examining the bird is not stalling. The Association of Avian Veterinarians keeps a member directory of avian-experienced vets; find one before you need one and write the number on page 27.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Fluffing briefly while resting, or settling for the night	Fluffed with eyes closing in the middle of the day, or sitting on the cage floor
Loud contact calling at dawn and dusk	New screaming through the day, or a bird that has gone quiet and still
Preening hard, and loose feathers evenly on both sides during a molt	Bare patches the bird can reach, broken feather shafts, or bleeding skin
An occasional single egg from a hen that passes normally	Repeated clutches, straining, or an egg that does not arrive
One or two sneezes with no discharge	Repeated sneezing, wet nostrils, a stained cere, or any change in voice

PBFD & polyomavirus

Two viruses with no treatment, both of which you manage by keeping them out of the house.

Psittacine beak and feather disease (PBFD)

Cause: psittacine circovirus, documented in lovebirds among many parrot species. **Signs:** the classic form starts with loss of the powder down that normally dusts the beak, then abnormal feather development, clubbed or hemorrhaging feathers that shed easily and regrow poorly, and beak deformity. A peracute form in young birds shows as weight loss, enteritis and pneumonia rather than feather change. **Transmission:** inhalation or ingestion of the virus, possibly also from parent to chick, and the virus is very stable in the environment, so cages, toys and clothing carry it. **Diagnosis:** PCR on blood, feces or feather dander; PCR also detects birds carrying it without signs. **Reality check:** there is no cure and no vaccine, and clinically affected birds are generally isolated with a poor outlook.

Avian polyomavirus

Cause: avian polyomavirus, most dangerous to young birds; infection is often fatal in psittacines under four months old. **Signs:** in nestlings, sudden lethargy, a crop that stops emptying, and death within 24 to 48 hours; survivors and older birds may show feather dystrophy. **Diagnosis:** DNA testing on a cloacal swab and blood. **Prevention:** a vaccine exists, with the first dose given after 35 days of age and a booster 2 to 3 weeks later. Discuss it with an avian vet if you are buying young birds or keeping several. Adults typically resist infection but can shed the virus for up to 90 days before clearing it, which is exactly why a healthy-looking new bird is still a risk to a resident one.

QUARANTINE EVERY NEW BIRD. THIS IS THE WHOLE PREVENTION STRATEGY.

A minimum of **30 days** apart, which is the public-health floor. Merck's figure for adding a bird to an aviary or an established multi-bird house is **90 days** of quarantine with testing, because an infected adult can shed polyomavirus intermittently for up to 90 days before clearing it. A separate room, ideally not sharing an air vent, with separate dishes and separate cleaning gear. Care for your established birds first and the new one last, and wash your hands and change your shirt in between. Book an avian vet exam in the first week and ask specifically about PCR screening for PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis. This is the one procedure that keeps an incurable virus out of a household, and it is skipped constantly.

Where exposure happens

- Bringing home a second bird without quarantine, which is the commonest route by a wide margin.
- Bird fairs, swaps, and shops where birds from many sources share air and surfaces.
- Secondhand cages and toys. A used cage is worth having, but strip it, scrub it, and disinfect it before a bird goes in.
- Your own hands and clothes after handling someone else's bird.

A DEFORMED FEATHER IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY PBFD

Damaged feathers also come from plucking, a bad molt, malnutrition, mites, and physical trauma to a follicle. The difference is not something to judge by eye, and guessing wrong in either direction is expensive. PCR testing is how it is settled, and it is worth doing rather than watching.

Respiratory disease @ psittacosis

The category that moves fastest, in the animal with the least reserve.

Recognizing it early

Watch for repeated sneezing, wet or crusted nostrils, a stained or discolored cere, discharge around the eyes, a change or loss of voice, fluffed posture, and a tail that bobs with each breath. Open-mouth breathing and audible wheezing are late signs in a small bird and mean an emergency, not an appointment next week. Causes range from bacterial and fungal infection to inhaled irritants and vitamin A deficiency, which thins the lining of the respiratory tract and makes recurrent sinus infections likely in a seed-fed bird.

RULE OUT THE AIR BEFORE THE BIRD

Before assuming infection, account for what the bird has been breathing: an overheated nonstick pan, an aerosol or air freshener, a scented candle, new paint, cigarette smoke, or a dusty room. Fume exposure and infection look similar from across the room and are treated completely differently. Page 8 has the full list.

Psittacosis, and why it matters to you as well as the bird

Cause: the bacterium *Chlamydia psittaci*. **How it spreads:** shed in feces, urine and respiratory secretions, and aerosolized into fine dust when birds beat their wings, so it is inhaled rather than needing contact. **Signs in the bird:** respiratory distress, nasal or eye discharge, appetite loss, bright green droppings, and regurgitation. Some birds carry it with no signs at all, and lovebirds specifically are among the species that may show nothing before sudden death. **Diagnosis:** PCR is the preferred test, sometimes alongside bloodwork and radiographs.

Treatment: doxycycline for **45 days**, because the organism hides inside white blood cells and a short course does not clear it, followed by retesting to confirm.

THIS ONE IS ZOONOTIC

People catch psittacosis from birds. Symptoms appear roughly **5 to 14 days** after exposure, occasionally up to a month, and start as headache, muscle aches, high fever especially at night, and flu-like respiratory illness. If anyone in the house develops that after a bird has been unwell, tell your own doctor about the bird. It is treatable in people and it is missed when nobody mentions the exposure. Ventilate when cleaning the cage, dampen droppings rather than sweeping dust into the air, and wash your hands afterward.

Supportive care while you get to the vet

- Warmth, around **80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C)**, in a quiet draft-free room. That sits inside LafeberVet's 80 to 90°F (27 to 32°C) range for a bird under supplemental heat; VCA puts a recovering bird's ideal at 75 to 80°F (22 to 25°C). Stop if the bird shows flat sleek feathers, wings held out, or open-mouth breathing, which mean it is too hot.
- Quiet and dark, in a small carrier with a low perch or a folded towel rather than a tall cage it can fall in.
- Food and water within reach at floor level, since a weak bird will not climb for it.
- Nothing by mouth without instruction. Do not give leftover antibiotics or any over-the-counter bird remedy.

Feather plucking & behavioral health

Plucking is a symptom, not a diagnosis, and it has both medical and behavioral causes that look identical from across the room. The order matters: rule out the medical causes first, then fix the environment. Guessing behavioral and being wrong means an infection or a deficiency runs untreated for months while you rotate toys.

Medical causes to rule out

- Vitamin A deficiency, which lists feather picking among its signs
- Bacterial or fungal skin and follicle infection
- Mites and other external parasites
- Internal disease, including liver disease from a high-fat diet
- Pain from an old injury or an irritated follicle
- Airborne irritants, including tobacco smoke

Behavioral causes to fix

- Boredom, and a cage with nothing to destroy
- Too little sleep, under 10 hours of darkness
- A cage too small to move properly in
- Sexual frustration and hormonal triggers (page 17)
- Loneliness in a single bird not getting daily contact
- A household change: a move, a new pet, a schedule change

START WITH THE FOUR BASICS BEFORE ANYTHING COMPLEX

Cage size (page 5), sleep at 10 to 12 hours of darkness (page 7), a pellet-forward diet (page 10), and daily interaction (page 9). A surprising share of plucking cases trace back to one of those four, and all four are free to fix. Add foraging before you add toys: making the bird work for its food is the enrichment with the most evidence behind it.

The other boredom behaviors

Plucking is one of three signals that the same problem produces. The other two are **repetitive pacing**, walking the same stretch of perch or cage front over and over, and **screaming** that is new, louder, or goes well past the normal dawn and dusk contact calling. Treat all three the same way: a vet check to exclude a medical cause, then a hard look at sleep, foraging, cage size and daily contact. Screaming in particular is often accidentally trained, because running into the room is exactly the response the bird wanted. Reward the quiet, answer a normal contact call, and ignore the escalation.

What not to do

- Do not fit a collar or a "no-pluck" spray as a first move. They treat the visible behavior and leave the cause running.
- Do not punish it. Plucking is a stress behavior and adding stress makes it worse.
- Do not assume feathers will grow back. Repeatedly damaged follicles can stop producing, so early intervention matters more than a perfect diagnosis.

Nutritional disease, mites & injuries

Less dramatic than the last three pages, and far more likely to be what you actually deal with.

Vitamin A deficiency

The quiet one behind a long list of other problems. All-seed diets, and even half-seed half-pellet diets that are not portion controlled, are deficient in vitamin A. It shows as nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eyes, conjunctivitis, labored breathing, increased thirst and urination, poor feather quality, feather picking, and appetite loss, and white plaques can appear around the mouth and eyes. Chronic sinus infections in a seed-fed bird usually mean this is underneath them. The fix is the diet on page 10, with the orange and dark green vegetables on page 11 doing most of the work. Injectable vitamin A is a veterinary treatment, not a home one.

Obesity and fatty liver disease

Seed, nuts and table food, plus a bird that never flies, deposit fat in the liver. Signs are subtle at first: poor feather condition, a rounded chest, exercise intolerance, and lameness or sore feet from carrying the weight. It is diagnosed on examination and bloodwork, and it is one of the reasons an annual wellness panel is worth the money in a seed-fed bird. Correct it gradually through diet and flight, never by sharply cutting food, which can tip a bird into a worse metabolic problem.

Scaly face and leg mites

Knemidocoptes mites burrow into the skin of the cere, beak corners, eyelids, legs and vent, producing a white, crusty, honeycombed encrustation. It is common in budgerigars and much less common in other parrots, so in a lovebird it is worth testing rather than assuming, but it does occur and lovebirds are named among the species affected. It is treated with a prescription antiparasitic and, because mites hide in porous surfaces, by replacing wooden perches and toys and disinfecting the cage at the same time. Untreated, it deforms the beak permanently.

Injuries and the overgrown beak

The common ones are a broken blood feather (page 15), a night fright collision, a fall from an over-short wing clip, a toe caught in a loose fiber or an open clip, and a cat or dog bite, which is always a same-day visit. Bleeding from a nail or the beak tip is handled with cornstarch and pressure; bleeding from anywhere else is a vet call. An overgrown or flaking beak is not normal wear in a bird with things to chew, and it can point to liver disease, mites, or malnutrition, so it warrants an exam rather than a trim.

A CAT OR DOG BITE IS AN EMERGENCY EVEN WHEN THE BIRD LOOKS FINE

Bacteria carried in cat saliva can kill a small bird within a day or two of a puncture that barely breaks skin. Any contact with a cat's mouth or claws is a same-day avian vet visit for antibiotics, whether or not you can see a wound.

THE COMMON THREAD

Five of the six conditions on this page start in the food bowl or in the cage furniture. The diet on page 10, the sleep and light schedule on page 7, and an annual wellness exam prevent more of this list than any treatment cures.

Molt, hormones & seasonal behavior

Molting

Feathers wear out and get replaced, and in a healthy bird this happens gradually rather than all at once. Merck's picture is a full molt at least once a year, with many birds also running a smaller partial molt about six months after the main one. The tells that a molt is normal are that it is **symmetrical**, roughly matching on both sides of the body, and that new feathers are already pushing through before the old ones drop, so bare skin never shows. New feathers arrive as **pin feathers**, each in a keratin sheath the bird flakes off by preening. Head pins are the ones the bird cannot reach itself, which is why a bonded bird gets them preened by its partner and a single bird may appreciate very gentle help from you.

MOLTING IS METABOLICALLY EXPENSIVE

Growing a full set of feathers is hard work, and a molting bird is often quieter, sleeps more, and can be touchier about being handled. Keep the diet up, offer baths two or three times a week to help the sheaths come away, and do not read the extra grumpiness as a training problem.

Bald patches, feathers missing only where the bird can reach, broken shafts, or bleeding pin feathers are not molting. Go to page 22 and book a vet exam.

Bathing and helping a molting bird

Offer a shallow dish of clean water two or three times a week, or a light misting for a bird that dislikes dishes. Bathing keeps feathers supple and helps a molting bird work the keratin sheaths off its new pin feathers. Never use soap, and let the bird dry in a draft-free room rather than under a hair dryer, which can carry PTFE-coated heating elements (page 8).

Hormonal seasons

Lengthening days, plentiful food and a secure territory push a lovebird into breeding condition, and the behavior that comes with it is genuine and temporary. Expect more territorial defense of the cage, more biting, regurgitating onto a favorite person or toy, shredding and carrying paper, sitting low on the cage floor, and in a hen, tail lifting when her back is stroked. This is the season to be least ambitious about handling and most disciplined about the triggers on page 17. Cut the day length, take out the nest-like objects, stop stroking anywhere but the head and neck, and wait it out.

Normal noise, and when it is not

Lovebirds are loud for their size and are especially vocal at dawn and dusk. That contact calling is normal flock behavior and cannot be trained away, only accommodated. What is worth investigating is a change: a bird that suddenly screams through the whole day, or one that has gone quiet and still. Both are worth attention, and the quiet one is the more urgent of the two.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

Molt: feather loss even on both sides, pins visible, skin covered, bird otherwise normal. **Plucking:** loss only where the beak reaches, head untouched, broken shafts. **PBFD:** deformed or clubbed new feathers, feathers that shed easily and regrow badly, beak changes, and no powder down. The first needs nothing, the second needs a vet and an environment audit, the third needs a PCR test.

Reading droppings & hydration

The cheapest daily health check you get, and a small bird gives you dozens of chances at it. Most birds pass a dropping every 20 to 30 minutes.

Every dropping has three parts, and telling them apart is the whole skill. The **fecal** part is the solid, coiled, worm-like portion, green or brown depending on diet. The **urates** are the chalky white part, made of uric acid crystals. The **urine** is the clear liquid rim around the edge. Line the cage with plain white paper and you can read all three at a glance.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
Coiled green or brown solid, white urates, small clear rim	Normal	Nothing. Learn what your bird's normal looks like on the diet it eats
Blue, purple, orange or red tinge after a specific food	Food coloring: berries, colored pellets, beets	Nothing, if it tracks a food and clears within a day
Lots of clear liquid, but the solid part still formed	Polyuria, excess urine. Often just watery food, fruit or cooked vegetables. If the diet is dry, it can be kidney or liver disease, infection or stress, and VCA notes polyuria is often the first sign of kidney damage from zinc (page 8)	Recheck after 24 hours on the usual diet. Still watery, call the vet
Unformed, loose, or pudding-like solid part	True diarrhea, which is far less common than polyuria and more serious	Vet. Take a photograph or the paper liner itself
Bright lime green, often with a poorly bird	Can point to liver involvement, including psittacosis (page 21)	Vet promptly
Black or tarry, or red streaking	Digested or fresh blood. Heavy metal poisoning is one cause	Vet the same day
Yellow or green urates instead of white	Liver disease	Vet promptly
Undigested seed passing through whole	The gut is not processing food properly. Merck lists whole seed in the droppings as a sign of avian gastric yeast, where a bird keeps eating and still loses weight	Vet, and weigh the bird
Very few droppings, or much smaller ones	The bird is eating less, or in a hen, an egg may be obstructing	Weigh the bird. In a hen, treat as urgent (page 17)

The working rule: droppings that are abnormal for more than 24 hours go to an avian vet promptly. Anything black, red, or accompanied by a fluffed, quiet bird does not wait the 24 hours. One noticeably larger dropping first thing in the morning is normal, and is the night's worth held over rather than a problem.

Hydration

- Fresh water in a clean dish daily, changed more often if the bird bathes or drops food in it. Wash the dish, do not just top it up: a biofilm builds fast in a warm room.
- Fresh vegetables contribute real water, which is part of why a bird eating well produces slightly wetter droppings than one on dry food alone.
- Signs a bird is dehydrated: dull, sunken-looking eyes, skin over the keel or toes that stays tented when lifted, thick sticky saliva, and dark, scant urates with almost no clear rim.
- A dehydrated bird is a vet visit, not a home rehydration project. Small birds need fluids given by a vet, and a bird too weak to drink will inhale water from a syringe.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Cage at least 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) single, 24×18×24 in (61×46×61 cm) pair, longer rather than taller
- ☐ Bar spacing 3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm), powder-coated or stainless steel
- ☐ Three or four perches, varied diameter, none over a dish
- ☐ Exterior-mount food, fresh-food and water dishes
- ☐ Small-parrot pellets, plus a fresh vegetable supply
- ☐ Cuttlebone or mineral block
- ☐ Foraging toy, shreddable items, and soft wood chews
- ☐ Plain breathable cage cover, and no hut, tent, nest box or mirror
- ☐ Digital scale reading to 1 g, with a perch
- ☐ Travel carrier, bought before you need it
- ☐ Single-versus-pair decision made deliberately (page 9)
- ☐ Avian vet identified and the number written on page 27

Environment targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Room temperature	65 to 80°F	18 to 27°C
Tolerable short-term range	60 to 85°F	16 to 29°C
Darkness, every night	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted	
Daylight for a hen who is laying repeatedly	Cut to 8 hours until laying stops (page 17)	
Humidity	Normal household. No misting or humidifier needed	
Out-of-cage time	1 to 2 hours daily in a bird-proofed room	
Direct interaction, single bird	About 2 hours daily	
Diet split	75 to 80% pellets, 20 to 40% fresh, seed as a treat	

Before your lovebird comes home

- ☐ Cage fully assembled, furnished and sited, for at least a day beforehand
- ☐ Quarantine room prepared if you already keep birds (page 20)
- ☐ A week's worth of whatever food the bird is already eating, to change over later
- ☐ Avian vet found and the first wellness appointment booked (page 29)

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The cage and the food. A cheap cage rusts and turns into a zinc exposure risk, and the bar spacing on a bargain cage is often wrong for a bird this size. Pellets cost pennies a day and prevent most of section 03. Save on toys instead: cardboard, untreated paper and unfinished soft wood are free or nearly so, and this species destroys them just as happily as the expensive versions.

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AVIAN VET NOW IF

Open-mouth breathing, wheezing, or tail bobbing at rest · a hen straining, sitting wide-legged, or fluffed on the cage floor · bleeding that does not stop with two to three minutes of firm, steady pressure · any contact with a cat or dog, even with no visible wound · a fall, a collision, or a bird found on the cage floor · sudden lethargy, collapse, or a bird that will not eat · exposure to fumes from an overheated pan, aerosol, or smoke.

READING	°F	°C
Room temperature	65 to 80°F	18 to 27°C
Warm, quiet room for a sick bird	80 to 85°F	27 to 29°C
Darkness every night	10 to 12 hours	
Cage minimum, single / pair	18×18×24 in / 24×18×24 in (46×46×61 / 61×46×61 cm)	
Bar spacing	3/8 to 5/8 in (10 to 16 mm)	
Healthy adult weight	40 to 60 g. A 10% drop is a vet call	
Routine avian checkup	\$25 to \$50	

Your numbers

Avian vet _____

Normal weight, in grams _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

Leg band or microchip number _____

Bird's name and hatch date _____

Last vet visit _____

Have this ready when you call

- ☐ Today's weight and the bird's normal weight
 ☐ The diet, honestly, split into pellets, seed and fresh food
 ☐ Single bird or pair, sex if known, and any egg-laying history
- ☐ When the signs started and whether they are worsening
 ☐ What the droppings look like now versus normal
 ☐ Anything new in the house: a bird, a toy, a cooking incident, a spray, a candle

GETTING THERE

Move the bird into a small carrier with a folded towel on the floor rather than a perch, cover it, and keep the car warm and quiet. Take the cage liner from this morning with you. Do not offer food or water in a moving car, and do not give anything by mouth on the way.

SECTION 05 • OWNER TOOLS

Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges, itemized so the lines actually add up to the totals. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Cage, 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) or larger, powder-coated or stainless steel	\$80 to \$150
Perches, varied diameter and material	\$20 to \$35
Shreddable and chew toys, starter set	\$20 to \$40
Foraging toy or box	\$10 to \$20
Exterior-mount dishes, set of three	\$10 to \$20
Plain breathable cage cover	\$10 to \$20
Digital scale reading to 1 g, with perch	\$15 to \$30
Travel carrier	\$20 to \$35
Cuttlebone or mineral block	\$5 to \$10
Equipment subtotal	\$190 to \$360
First avian vet exam	\$25 to \$50
All-in before the bird arrives	\$215 to \$410
The bird itself: \$50 to \$150 common, \$200 to \$400+ for a rare mutation, \$20 to \$100 to adopt	\$20 to \$400+
MONTHLY ONGOING, ONE BIRD	TYPICAL COST
Small-parrot pellets	\$6 to \$10
Fresh vegetables and fruit	\$7 to \$12
Replacement toys and shreddables	\$5 to \$15
Cage liner paper and cleaning supplies	\$1 to \$3
Annual wellness exam and testing, averaged	\$6 to \$10
Monthly ongoing	\$25 to \$50
A bonded pair, same lines doubled on food, toys and vet care	\$45 to \$90

Published monthly figures for this species vary a lot, largely because some fold the annual vet bill and a toy habit into the number and others do not. These lines are itemized so you can see which parts your household will actually spend. A year that includes a course of medication or an emergency runs well above any of them.

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

Egg binding, a broken blood feather, a night fright injury, a cat bite, or a 45-day course of doxycycline. Any one of these turns a \$25 to \$50 checkup into a bill in the hundreds, and an after-hours emergency clinic charges more again. A few hundred dollars set aside matters more than any single item on this list.

First 30 days checklist

Day 1

- ☐ Weigh the bird in grams and photograph it and the setup for a baseline
- ☐ Leave it alone. Food, water, quiet, and no handling. Talk to it from across the room
- ☐ Fill in the numbers on page 27 and the equipment dates on page 35
- ☐ If you already keep birds, the new one is in a separate room on separate air (page 20)

Week 1

- ☐ Feed exactly what the bird was already eating. Diet changes wait until it has settled
- ☐ Book a wellness visit with an avian vet, and ask about PCR screening for PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis
- ☐ Audit the cage against page 26: bar spacing measured, no hut, tent, nest box or mirror
- ☐ Bird-proof the room you will use for out-of-cage time (page 8)

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Start the pellet conversion on one of the two schedules on page 10, weighing every few days
- ☐ Begin taming: sitting beside the cage, then millet through the bars, then stick training in a neutral room (page 14)
- ☐ Set the bedtime and stick to it, 10 to 12 hours of darkness every night
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 34 with a weekly weigh-in

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. A stable adult weight is the goal, and a downward trend is a vet call
- ☐ Check the fresh food is being eaten, not just shredded. Try rejected items again a different way
- ☐ Introduce the first foraging toy and start the enrichment rotation on page 36

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Finish quarantine at 30 days minimum, 45 to 60 in a multi-bird house, and only then share air and space
- ☐ Book any follow-up the vet recommended, and record the test results on page 35
- ☐ Watch for the first hormonal signs, especially in a hen: paper shredding, floor sitting, tail lifting (page 17)
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for slow drift in weight, appetite, or droppings
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet on page 33 before you need it

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Straining, wide-legged, fluffed on the cage floor, no egg	Egg binding	Avian vet the same day (page 18)
Repeated clutches beyond an occasional egg	Chronic egg laying	Cut light to 8 hours, remove nest sites, see a vet (page 17)
Tail bobbing at rest, open-mouth breathing, wheezing	Respiratory disease, or fume exposure	Emergency. Ventilate, then vet (pages 8 and 21)
Sneezing, wet nostrils, stained cere, eye discharge	Respiratory infection or vitamin A deficiency	Vet promptly (pages 21 and 23)
Bright green droppings in an unwell bird	Possible psittacosis or liver involvement	Vet promptly, and mention it to your own doctor (page 21)
Deformed or clubbed feathers, beak changes, no powder down	Possible PBFD	PCR testing, and isolate from other birds (page 20)
A young bird suddenly lethargic with a full crop	Possible polyomavirus	Emergency vet visit (page 20)
Feather loss only where the beak reaches, head untouched	Plucking, medical or behavioral	Vet first to exclude medical, then audit the environment (page 22)
Even feather loss on both sides, pins visible, skin covered	Normal molt	Nothing. Keep the diet up and offer baths (page 24)
White crusty growth on the cere, beak corners or legs	Possible <i>Knemidocoptes</i> mites	Vet for diagnosis and antiparasitic treatment (page 23)
Watery droppings, solid part still formed	Polyuria, often watery food	Recheck at 24 hours, then vet (page 25)
Black, tarry or bloody droppings	Bleeding, possibly heavy metal poisoning	Vet the same day (pages 5 and 25)
Appetite loss, regurgitation, weakness, excessive thirst	Possible zinc or lead poisoning from cage or toys	Vet, and take a photo of the cage and toys (page 6)
Sudden collapse or death near the kitchen	PTFE fumes from overheated cookware	Ventilate immediately, get remaining birds out, vet (page 8)
New biting, cage defense, regurgitating on a person or toy	Hormonal season	Cut day length, remove triggers, hold off on handling (page 24)
New all-day screaming, or pacing the same stretch of perch	Boredom, too little sleep, or too little contact	Vet check, then foraging, sleep and interaction (page 22)
Rounded chest, keel hard to feel, exercise intolerance	Obesity and fatty liver	Diet change and daily flight, gradually (page 16)
Bleeding from a growing feather	Broken blood feather	Firm, steady pressure; powder on the broken tip, never into the follicle. Vet at 2 to 3 minutes (page 15)
Any contact with a cat or dog	Puncture and bacterial infection risk	Vet the same day even with no visible wound (page 8)
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet, and bring the Owner Log (page 34)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Fresh pellets and clean water, dish washed rather than topped up
- ☐ Chopped fresh vegetables in the morning, removed within about three hours
- ☐ Change the paper liner and read the droppings before you bin it (page 25)
- ☐ 1 to 2 hours out of the cage, and about 2 hours of interaction for a single bird
- ☐ Cover or lights out at a fixed time, for 10 to 12 hours of darkness
- ☐ Quick visual check: posture, breathing, eyes, nostrils, feet, feather condition

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it on page 34
- ☐ Rotate the toys, keeping 3 to 5 in the cage
- ☐ Offer a bath two or three times, or mist the bird
- ☐ Scrub the dishes and wipe the perches and bars

Monthly

- ☐ Full cage deep clean, including the tray and grate
- ☐ Check perches for wear and replace any that have been chewed thin
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends, not just single readings

Every 3 months

- ☐ Check the nails and beak, and book a vet trim if the nails catch on fabric
- ☐ Re-audit the room for new hazards: a new candle, a new pan, a new houseplant

Seasonal

- ☐ As daylight lengthens in spring, hold the bird's night at 10 to 12 hours with a cover or a timer
- ☐ Expect a hormonal season and a molt. Ease off handling, keep the diet up, offer more baths (page 24)
- ☐ Check heating and cooling changes have not put the cage in a draft or in direct sun

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam, with a blood panel for any bird that has been on a seed-heavy diet
- ☐ Replace supplements and the cuttlebone, and refresh the emergency kit on page 32

THE THREE-HOUR RULE

Fresh food spoils fast at room temperature, faster under a warm cage light. Put it in each morning and take it out within about three hours, before it can grow anything. Moldy food is a real cause of avian illness, and the tray under the cage is where it hides.

Power outages, travel & transport

A lovebird needs no heat lamp, so an outage is mostly a question of room temperature and of what people start burning for light and warmth.

When the power goes out

Do

- Move the cage to the warmest interior room, away from windows and exterior doors.
- Cover three sides and the top with blankets, leaving one side open for air. Trapped body heat does most of the work at this size.
- Keep feeding normally. A 50 g bird has almost no reserve and skipping meals is a bigger risk than being cool.
- Keep the day and night cycle roughly normal with a battery lantern rather than leaving the bird in the dark all day.

Don't

- Don't use candles, kerosene, gas stoves, or any open flame near the bird. Smoke and combustion fumes are the real danger of an outage for a bird, not the temperature.
- A generator runs outside and **at least 20 feet from any door, window or vent**, which is the CDC's figure. The CPSC's wording rules out running one in or *near* an enclosed space, so an open garage door does not qualify.
- Don't use a camping heater, a self-cleaning oven cycle, or a hair dryer to warm the room. Several carry PTFE-coated elements.

OUTAGE KIT

Battery lantern, blankets, a hot water bottle wrapped in a towel and set near the carrier rather than against it, a week of pellets in a sealed tub, bottled water, a working carbon monoxide detector, and the carrier itself kept where you can reach it in the dark. Skip chemical hand warmers: some vent fumes, and nothing that off-gasses belongs beside a bird.

Leaving town

TRIP LENGTH	SINGLE BIRD	BONDED PAIR
1 night	Possible with full dishes, but a visit is better. The risk is a spilled water dish, not hunger	Same, and they at least have each other for company
2 to 3 nights	A daily sitter. Fresh food and water every day, and eyes on the bird	A daily sitter
Over 3 nights	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with an avian vet or a bird-specific shop. Leave the sheet on page 33 filled in.	

A single hand-raised lovebird is bonded to you, so a long absence is a social problem as much as a husbandry one. Expect a period of loud contact calling when you get back, and some birds pluck after a long separation.

Transport and vet trips

- A small hard-sided carrier with a low perch, or a folded towel on the floor for a sick bird, is safer than the cage. Cover it: a covered bird travels calmly.
- Belt the carrier in, keep the car quiet, and never run the air conditioning or heat straight onto it.
- Take the morning's cage liner to the appointment. It is the sample the vet actually wants.
- Never leave the bird in a parked car, hot or cold, even briefly. A car interior kills a small bird faster than it would a dog.
- Clip a spare wing check and a photograph of the bird into the carrier lid, in case it gets out at the clinic door.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE CAGE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Bird's name _____

Avian vet _____

Age and normal weight in grams _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Fresh water in a washed dish, and top up the pellet dish | ☐ Look at the bird: is it alert, breathing quietly, standing normally? |
| ☐ A small amount of chopped vegetables, removed on the next visit | ☐ Cover the cage at the usual bedtime, uncover in the morning |
| ☐ Change the paper liner, and glance at the droppings before binning it | ☐ Wash your hands before and after. Don't rinse dishes in a sink used for food prep |

Please don't

- Don't cook with nonstick pans, use aerosols, air fresheners, scented candles, or smoke anywhere in the house while the bird is here. Fumes that are harmless to you can kill a bird within minutes.
- Don't let the bird out of the cage, and don't open a window or exterior door in that room.
- Don't reach into the cage. Use the exterior dishes. This bird bites when it feels cornered.
- Don't add a mirror, a hut, or anything nest-like, however cozy it looks. Don't feed anything not on this sheet.
- Don't move the cage, change a timer, or leave a light on past the usual bedtime.

Notes on this bird

Food and amounts _____

Bedtime and wake time _____

Quirks, warnings, favorite treats _____

CALL ME IF

The bird is sitting fluffed with its eyes closing during the day, on the floor of the cage, breathing with its tail bobbing or its mouth open, bleeding, not eating, or if it gets out. If I don't answer, call the vet number above. A bird that looks a little off in the morning can be seriously ill by evening, so please call early rather than waiting.

Owner log

One row a week. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	APPETITE	DROPPINGS	EGGS	MOLT	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

Weight is the one number that moves before a lovebird looks unwell, and a bird that hides illness gives you nothing else to work with. Weigh at the same time of day, before the first feed, and write it down even when nothing has changed: the value is in the line, not the reading. Sixteen rows is four months, long enough to see a real trend, and it is the single most useful thing you can hand a vet.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
Cage and perches, condition checked			
Full-spectrum lamp, if used (output falls before the bulb dies)			
Cuttlebone or mineral block			
Pellet bag opened (buy in sizes you finish, not bulk)			
Scale batteries, and outage kit checked			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Start with whichever month you're in.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Perch and toy audit	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Nails and beak checked	☐			☐			☐			☐		
Household hazard sweep	☐			☐			☐			☐		
Wellness exam	☐											☐

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON, FINDINGS AND TEST RESULTS	FOLLOW-UP

Record the PBFD, polyomavirus and psittacosis screening results here with their dates. A future vet, a boarding facility, or anyone you ever rehome the bird to will want them, and a negative result from three years ago is not the same as a current one.

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ 3 to 5 toys in the cage, mixing forage, shred and chew rather than duplicates
- ☐ At least part of the daily ration served inside a foraging toy, not in the dish
- ☐ Perches at varied heights and diameters, with room to fly between them
- ☐ A dedicated bird-proofed room for daily out-of-cage time

Weekly and monthly review

- ☐ Rotate the toys weekly, and put retired ones away rather than binning them
- ☐ Change the foraging method every few days so it stays a puzzle
- ☐ Two or three short training sessions a week: step up, target, recall
- ☐ Try one new safe food from pages 11 to 12

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

ENRICHMENT SAFETY

Check every toy weekly for loose fibers a toe can wrap in, small detachable parts, open metal clips, and any galvanized metal. Replace shredded items before the bird works its way down to the hardware. And remember what enrichment cannot do: it does not substitute for sleep, for a correct diet, or for daily contact with a single bird, and a cage full of toys will not stop a bird plucking if any of those three is missing.

Glossary

<i>Agapornis</i>	The genus of the nine lovebird species, from the Greek for "love bird," after the pair bond.
Blood feather	A growing feather with a live blood supply in the shaft. Cutting, breaking or pulling one causes real bleeding.
Bonded pair	Two lovebirds paired to each other, often for life. A bonded pair bonds to each other rather than to a keeper.
Cere	The fleshy area above the beak containing the nostrils. Staining or crusting there is a respiratory sign.
Chronic egg laying	Repeated clutches beyond an occasional egg, driven by hormonal triggers and hard on a hen's calcium reserves.
Contra-freeloading	The documented tendency of parrots to work for food even when identical food is freely available, which is why foraging toys matter.
Egg binding	An egg that cannot pass. A life-threatening emergency requiring same-day veterinary care.
Happy hut	An enclosed, tent or tunnel-shaped fabric hide sold for cage birds. A documented hormonal trigger, and not for a pet lovebird.
Hepatic lipidosis	Fatty liver disease, usually from a high-fat diet and too little exercise.
Hypocalcemia	Low blood calcium. In hens it follows repeated laying on a calcium-poor diet, and causes weakness, tremors and fractures.
Keel	The ridge of breastbone down the center of the chest. Feeling it either side is how body condition is judged.
<i>Knemidocoptes</i>	The mite that causes scaly face and leg disease, seen as white crusty encrustation on the cere, beak corners and legs.
Molt	The normal replacement of feathers, symmetrical on both sides, with new feathers emerging before old ones drop.
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease, an incurable circovirus affecting feathers, beak and the immune system.
Photoperiod	The daily light and dark cycle. 10 to 12 hours of darkness is routine; 8 hours of light is the level used to break a laying cycle.
Pin feather	A new feather still in its keratin sheath, which the bird flakes off by preening.
Polyomavirus	A virus most dangerous to young birds, often fatal under four months. A vaccine exists.
Polyuria	Excess urine: a watery dropping whose solid part is still formed. Different from diarrhea, and usually less serious.
Powder down	Fine feather dust that normally keeps a parrot's beak looking matte. Its loss is an early PBFD sign.
Psittacosis	Infection with <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> , treatable with a 45-day course of doxycycline, and transmissible to people.
PTFE	The nonstick coating that releases a gas lethal to birds when a pan is overheated to about 536°F (280°C).
Quarantine	Keeping a new bird separate, ideally on separate air, for 30 days minimum before it meets resident birds.
Urates	The chalky white portion of a dropping, made of uric acid. Yellow or green urates point to liver disease.
Zoonotic	Transmissible from animals to people. Psittacosis is the one that matters in this species.

Sources, version history & about

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary and scientific sources

- Merck Veterinary Manual: Reproductive Diseases of Pet Birds; Viral Diseases of Pet Birds; Nutritional Diseases of Pet Birds; Toxicoses of Pet Birds; Parasitic Diseases of Pet Birds.
- VCA Animal Hospitals: Lovebirds, General; Lovebirds, Feeding; Fruits and Vegetables in Bird Diets; Birds, Abnormal Droppings; Chronic Egg Laying in Birds; Knemidokoptic Mange in Birds; Recognizing the Signs of Illness in Pet Birds.
- Lafeber: Psittacosis, What Bird Owners Need to Know; Lovebird species profile; Switching from Seeds to Pellets (Stephanie Lamb, DVM); Is Your Pet Bird a Healthy Weight? (Susan Orosz, DVM).
- LafeberVet: Basic Information Sheet for the Lovebird, for the weight, life span and 18 to 24 day incubation figures; Body Condition Scoring in Birds; Avian Emergency and Critical Care, for the supplemental-heat range and the signs of overheating; Grooming Companion Birds, A Review; Reproductive Emergencies in Birds.
- VCA Animal Hospitals: Wing Clipping; Blood or Pin Feathers in Birds; Egg Binding in Birds; Sexual Behavior in Birds; Nursing Care for Sick Pet Birds; Transporting Your Bird.
- NASPHV and CDC, Compendium of Measures to Control *Chlamydia psittaci* Infection Among Humans and Pet Birds, for the 30-day quarantine floor and the 45-day doxycycline course.
- UC Davis School of Veterinary Medicine, Clinical Animal Behavior Service, for the 10 to 12 hour sleep figure and the note that covering a cage may not give optimal rest.
- US CDC and Consumer Product Safety Commission, for the 20-foot generator distance and the carbon monoxide guidance on page 32.
- Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006), on the behavior of adult hand-reared against parent-reared parrots, for the note on page 9.
- Association of Avian Veterinarians, for the avian-vet directory referenced on page 19.

Husbandry references

- Investigating the use of odour and colour foraging cues by rosy-faced lovebirds (*Agapornis roseicollis*), for the foraging behavior behind the enrichment page.
- Beastly Facts lovebird guides: cage setup, handling, health issues, cost, and enrichment, current at the time of publication.
- Beastly Facts cross-species bird guides, written since version 2.0 and now carrying the pages this package used to source externally: household hazards, photoperiod and sleep, pellet conversion, quarantine, droppings, wing clipping, sexing and body condition, feather loss and molt, chronic egg laying, emergency and travel, first aid and grooming, body language, and choosing a pet bird.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Six figures where credible references do not match, and what this package prints instead.

- **Cage minimum.** Common husbandry guidance gives 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) for a single bird; VCA's lovebird profile gives a considerably larger 3×2×2 ft (90×60×60 cm). Both are printed on page 5 rather than picking one, because the smaller figure is a floor and the larger is a better target.
- **Diet split.** Pellet shares between 60 and 80% appear in circulation. This package uses the 75 to 80% pellets and 20 to 40% fresh figures from VCA's lovebird feeding guidance, which is the species-specific source.
- **Adult weight.** This package prints 40 to 60 g, which is the range the site's own lovebird guides carry. LafeberVet's basic information sheet gives **45 to 70 g, mean 50**. Both are printed here rather than silently picking one, and the practical answer on page 16 is unchanged: your own bird's stable baseline matters more than either range.
- **Captive life span.** VCA and the site's cost guide give 10 to 15 years typical and about 20 at most, which is what pages 4 and 16 print. LafeberVet gives a **mean of 15 years with up to 30 reported**. The planning consequence does not change: this is a bird you keep for well over a decade.
- **Room temperature.** The site's lovebird cage-setup guide gives 65 to 80°F (18 to 27°C), which page 7 prints. LafeberVet gives **70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)** as generally acceptable, adding that healthy birds tolerate more in both directions. The draft and the sudden swing matter more than the number.
- **Monthly cost.** Published monthly figures for this species vary by a factor of three. Page 28 itemizes the lines instead, so the total is one you can check against your own receipts.

Version history

VERSION	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
2.1 · Sep 2026	t3	Corrections pass. Every page was cross-checked against the site's new cross-species bird articles: household hazards, photoperiod and sleep, pellet conversion, quarantine, droppings, wing clipping, sexing and body condition, feather loss and molt, chronic egg laying, emergency and travel, first aid and grooming, body language, and choosing a pet bird. Weighing moved from weekly to daily, blood-feather first aid was corrected to firm pressure with no pulling at home, the incubation figure moved to LafeberVet's 18 to 24 days for the species, the sick-bird warming figure was harmonized across pages 18, 21 and 27, and the quarantine, generator, avocado, molt and droppings figures were re-sourced. The back matter split into two reference pages, 38 and 39, which took the guide from 38 pages to 39.
2.0 · Sep 2026	t3	Full rebuild on the current template, 21 pages to 38. New pages on household hazards and PTFE fumes, light and sleep, wing clipping, three food charts, sexing and body condition, molt and hormonal seasons, reading droppings, quarantine, power outages and travel, and a pet-sitter sheet. Diet moved to 75 to 80% pellets, the budget was itemized so the lines sum, and every figure was re-sourced against veterinary references.
1.0 · Aug 2026	pre-t3	First edition, 21 pages on the earlier layout. Cage sizing and bar spacing, the single-versus-pair decision, diet, health red flags, egg binding, PBFD and feather plucking, plus checklists and an owner log.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources above and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an avian veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Free companion guides, updated as guidance changes, are at beastlyfacts.com.

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